



Built From The Ground Up

How The Seattle Seahawks Tore it All Down Then Built it Back Up To Become Champions

SANTA CLARA, Calif. — The confetti was yet to fall when Kenneth Walker III was hoisting the Lombardi Trophy. Seattle, at least, could now breathe in that moment. Twelve years. So long the city had been waiting to have this emotion. Seniority in almost missed chances and bitter defeats, in seeing a dynasty disintegrate, in asking yourself whether the team may ever have recovered.

The Long Way Back

The Seattle Seahawks responded to that question on Feb. 8, 2026. At Levi Stadium, they overpowered the New England Patriots in Super Bowl LX 29–13. That was not even the most memorable score. The way they did it was. Seattle has not won by having a star quarterback or a huge contract player. They won on a recovered QB, a punishing running game, the chip on the shoulder defense, and an administration that was true to its plan when most organizations would have given up.

It is a tale of a remodel that was done correctly.

The Fall Before the Rise

And to see what Seattle made, you must know what they have lost. In 2022, the team that had been taken to two Super Bowls in consecutive years had disintegrated. Head coach Pete Carroll was ad hoc. Russell Wilson was sold to Denver. The city had passed into a kind of stupor.

It would be followed by two additional seasons with Geno Smith as the starter. At some points, he performed well, and the team failed to overcome the top. Seattle went 9–8 in 2022 and 9–8 again in 2023. They missed the playoffs in 2024. Carroll was let go. Tyler Lockett was cut. DK Metcalf was traded. The list was being emptied.

John Schneider, the general manager who drafted Wilson and created the Legion of Boom, had to demonstrate his ability to do it once again. He had no Carroll. No Wilson. No Metcalf. No Lockett. Just a blank slate.

The Hire That Changed Everything

Schneider did just that in January 2025 and laid the foundation of the next chapter of Seahawks football. He employed Mike Macdonald as the coach. Macdonald was not even 36. He had worked as the defensive coordinator of the Baltimore Ravens in one season, during which his team was considered one of the top teams in the league. He was intelligent, daring, and not afraid to go against what other coaches would not have attempted.

Risk was perceived as a first-time head coach by other teams. Schneider saw a fit. The Seahawks would not out-run anybody in the NFC West. They were going to outwit them. Macdonald zone coverages and Blitz packages were constructed in such a way that they baffled the quarterbacks and caused havoc. He took the same style to Seattle.

The initial year of Macdonald was good but unequal. Seattle finished 10–7, losing the Wild Card in 2024. The team was one year away, as critics said. They were right. But the pieces were in place.

“We never waver, man. We believe in each other. We love each other, and now we’re world champions,”
– Coach Mike Macdonald

“There is more than one way to build a champion.”

Sam Darnold: The Right Man at the Right Time

The acquisition of Sam Darnold brought up numerous issues. Darnold was the third drafted player in 2018. He was a great tool in possession and, over the years, was known more by his failures than his victories. His stay with the Jets was tough. In Carolina and San Francisco, his years had their time but nowhere to go. The n in 2024 among the Vikings, it worked. Before Minnesota proceeded, he threw 4,319 yards and 35 TDs and had some of the best football of his career.

Seattle contracted him to a prove-it contract. The crime was constructed in such a way that it relieved the QB. Short throws. A strong ground game. Allow the defense to do the heavy lifting. Darnold has made a 67.7 percent completion rate with 8.5 yards per attempt. They both were the masterpieces of his career. Regarding their defense and how they have been playing, it was my duty to watch the football, as Darnold said after the Super Bowl win. That is what I knew to come into the game. I did that.” He became the youngest QB in the 2018 draft to win a Super Bowl.

Jaxon Smith-Njigba: The X-Factor

When Seattle released Metcalf and Lockett, the question was who was going to fill their shoes. Jaxon Smith-Njigba provided them with a response. In 2025, the second-year wide receiver became the first player in the entire league to receive 1,793 yards. He was Offensive Player of the Year, Pro Bowl, and first team All-Pro.

JSN does not burn fast and does not jump balls. He is a route runner. He makes all his routes with the same position to ensure that a defender does not have time to read him before the ball has been sent. He received 10 passes and had 153 yards and a touchdown against six opponents in the NFC title game against the Rams. The broadcasting Tom Brady stated that his body language on routes was that of a poker player without tells.

No other addition demonstrated where this team was going in such a way as Smith-Njigba did. He was not a stopgap. He was the foundation.



The Dark Side Defense

The Second Coming of the Legion of Boom had Finally Arrived

Any great championship team is identified. In this case of the Seahawks, it is what Macdonald constructed, and players referred to as the Dark Side.

Leonard Williams, a defensive tackle, anchored the interior with 7.0 sacks and 2 nd team All-Pro. Devon Witherspoon, a cornerback in his third season in the NFL, was transformed into one of the most efficient cover corners in the game. The middle was run by linebacker Ernest Jones IV. DeMarcus Lawrence recovered from the lost game of 2024 after missing most of 2024 due to a foot injury, which is also an edge rusher. Rookie safety Nick Emmanwori marked 18 quarterback pressures, the highest in the league during the whole season.

The unit was also leading in defense in the regular season. During the playoffs, it got even better. They had six sacks, three forced turnovers, and no fewer than 13 points against New England in the Super Bowl. The most desirable play of the game came late. When Maye threw, Witherspoon struck his arm. The tipped pass was in the air, and Uchenna Nwosu caught the pass and returned it 45 yards as a pick-six.

Kenneth Walker III: Winning the Biggest Stage

When Zach Charbonnet tore his ACL mid-way through the season, the workload fell entirely on Kenneth Walker III's shoulders. He delivered. Walker rushed for 1,027 yards and five touchdowns in the regular season, but it was his postseason performance that cemented his legacy.

In Super Bowl LX, Walker carried 27 of the team's 29 running back attempts for 135 yards, setting up field goal after field goal as Seattle built its lead. He was named Super Bowl MVP — the first running back to win the award since Terrell Davis in 1997's Super Bowl XXXII.

"It's just a dream come true because a lot of people play their whole career and never make it this far," Walker said. "We went through adversity throughout the season, but we stayed together. You know that adversity showed who we were as a team. We got a brotherhood going on right now, and it's special."

The Architect's Legacy

Something about what Schneider pulled off was reported by NFL media after the final whistle. He was the first general manager in NFL history to lead numerous Super Bowls with the same team as head coach and an entirely different team.

No Wilson. No Carroll. No Legion of Boom. Only Schneider, his talent eye, his faith in a 36-year-old defensive coach, and a locker room of players who buy into the plan. What Seattle demonstrated in 2025 is not difficult. One cannot make a champion in just one way. It is only a matter of finding your way out and not giving up when it is tough.

In Seattle, they had never retreated.

